

I know it might seem counterintuitive to pay more to save more, but at some point, you should save up to replace all your inefficient appliances with energy saving ones. This includes items like your dishwasher, toilet, and washing machine.

Energy efficient appliances are made to reduce the amount of water flow, thus decreasing your quarterly bill. For instance, a low-flow toilet uses as little as 1.6 gallons to flush, as opposed to the five to seven for conventional models. A dishwasher installed before 1994 wastes more than ten gallons per cycle, while an Energy Star appliance could save over 1,600 gallons over its lifetime. An older washing machine uses 23 gallons of water per load, compared to the thirteen gallons used by an energy efficient one.

If you can afford it, energy saving appliances are the way to go, and most allow you to claim a tax credit at the end of the year too. To find out more about what characteristics to look for in an energy efficient product, or which products will give you that tax credit, visit EnergyStar.gov.

6. MAKE A RAIN BARREL

One of the projects on our home wish list is a DIY rain barrel. We have strict watering laws here in Florida, and I know it would eliminate so much waste since it rains almost every single day!

If you're not familiar with what a rain barrel does, this tool collects water from rainstorms that can then be used to water your grass, garden, or houseplants without hooking into your main water system. It's essentially free water—nature gives it right to you.

Buying a rain barrel is certainly an option, but it's much cheaper to craft one yourself out of a garbage can and attach it to a rain gutter. Search “DIY rain barrel” on Pinterest, and you'll find a ton of tutorials to make your own.